

A decorative graphic in the top-left corner consisting of several dark green silhouettes of handloom parts, including bobbins and a shuttle, arranged in a cluster.

Product Photography Guide for Handloom Artisans

Bachelor Thesis Project

Aditya Pratap Singh
210205009

M. Thanush
210205031

Dr. Sharmistha Benarjee
Project Supervisor

The handloom industry, known for its rich cultural heritage and intricate craftsmanship, plays a vital role in supporting **rural economies**.

The industry has experienced steady growth in recent years, fueled by the increasing popularity of artisanal products and the emphasis on sustainability and uniqueness in consumer preferences.



1%

weavers and
artisans sell
product through
online channel

< 20%

of handloom products
make it to international
markets.

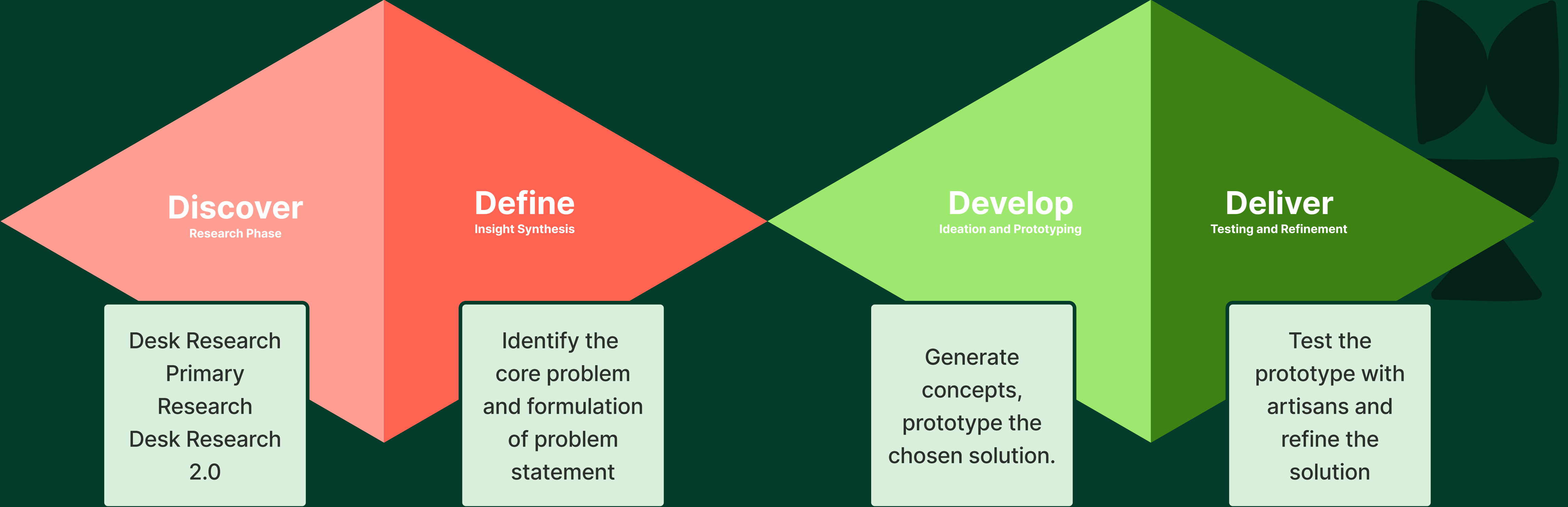
0.2%

of total sales for
handloom weavers
happens through
online channel



As the demand for authentic, handcrafted products grows globally, there is a significant opportunity to create digital solutions that can bridge the gap between artisans and consumers.

Design Process



HMW Statement

"How might we help
handloom artisans showcase
their craft to a wider audience
in a visually compelling and
informative way?"



What customers want to know?

- **Raw Fabric Presentation:** Displaying fabric in its raw, unironed state, with natural creases.
- **Highlighting Fabric Edges:** It provides insights into the material's thickness and weight.
- **Weight and Flow Representation:** Demonstrating folds, bumps, and the fabric's natural flow can tell about its weight and structure.
- **Storytelling and Connection:** Sharing the story behind the fabric to foster an emotional connection.

Flimsiness

Colour

Thickness

Transparency

Texture

Pattern

Material

Sheen

Embroidery

What mistakes does artisans make?

*Back
lighting*



Hazy picture

off alignment



Front lighting



Top lighting

Flat lay

off alignment

Artisans typically capture flat-lay pictures of their products by placing them on the floor or holding them up. While these images provide an overview of the design, they often fail to convey crucial material properties such as weight, texture, and transparency.

Lighting is usually inadequate

What mistakes does artisans make?



not enough emphasis on motif



Artisans do not effectively showcase intricate motifs. Some attempt to, but make mistakes in composing pictures, such as incorrect fabric orientation or lack of emphasis on details.

What mistakes does artisans make?



Back lighting

major empty space

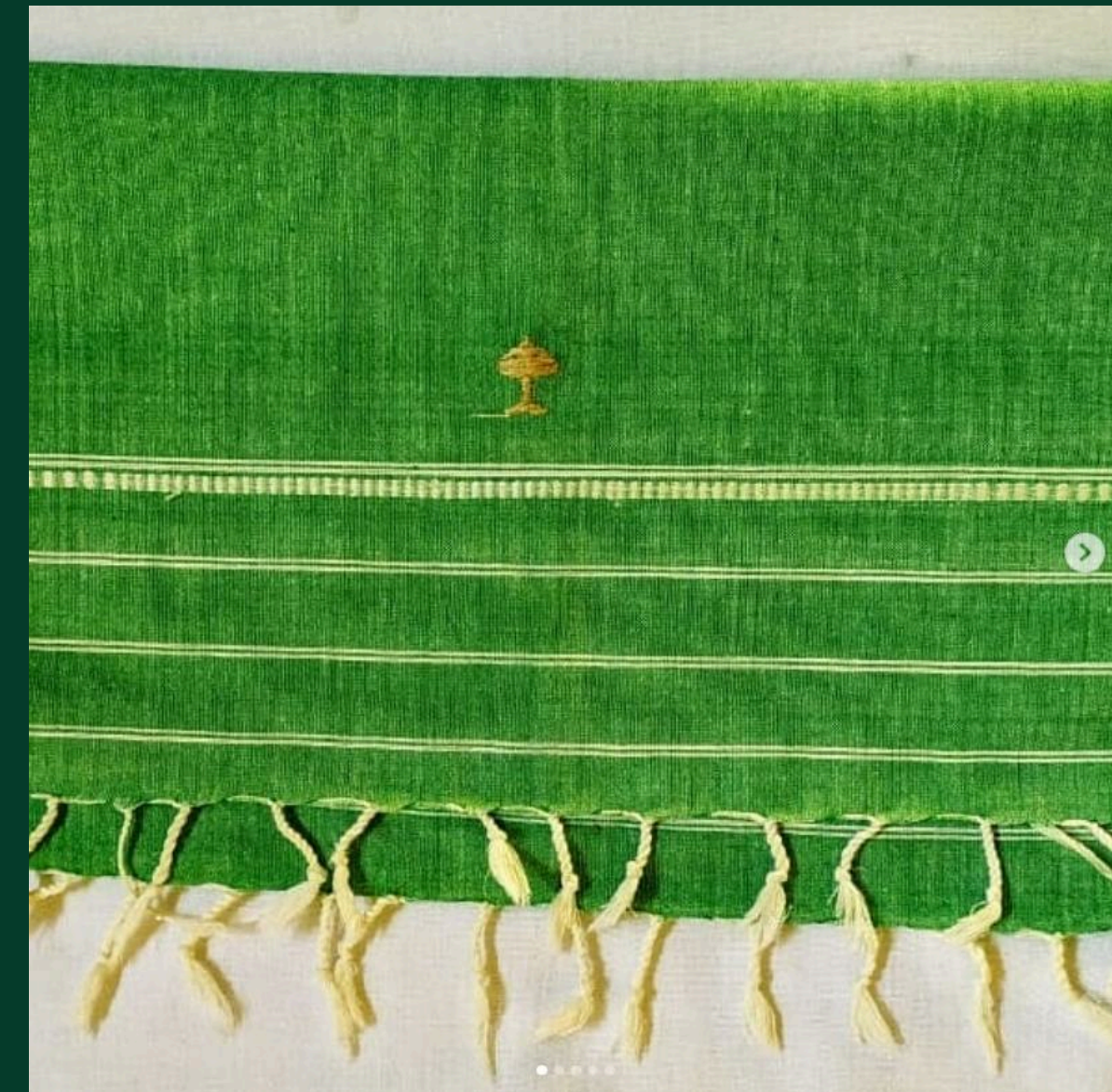


major empty space

off alignment

Some artisans attempt to capture the flow and natural fall of the fabric to convey its weight, but poor composition often undermines their efforts. For products like stole, it is very difficult to get an idea of the size, because they lack juxtaposition.

What mistakes does artisans make?



Following proper grid can improve the layout and alignment.

Borders are edge of the fabric often not highlighted or shown clearly, and when included, they are presented in a way that feels dull and unengaging.

Guidelines for Product Photography.

- **Use Close-Up Shots** – Capture fine details, textures, and craftsmanship of the fabric.
- **Highlight fabric edges** - Capture the edge of the fabric by covering 2/3 of the image with fabric.
- **Shoot from Various Angles** – Showcase the product from multiple perspectives to highlight its design and structure.
- **Experiment with Diverse Lighting** – Utilize natural and artificial lighting, Indoor and outdoor lighting, Front and side lighting, to bring out the true colors and depth of the fabric.
- **Choose Complementary Backgrounds** – Use backgrounds that enhance the fabric's beauty without overpowering it.
- **Embrace Natural Creases** – Photograph the fabric in its raw, unironed state to give a clear idea of material.
- **Represent Weight and Flow** – Capture how the fabric drapes, folds, and flows to convey its weight and feel.
- **Tell a Story** – Frame shots in a way that connects the fabric to its cultural heritage, artisans, and intended use.



matte finish. G4

reflective properties. G3

ast of the sheen. G5

1. Colour
- Use natural daylight or diffused artificial light to capture the true color. G4
 - Use a neutral or contrasting background to make the color pop. G5
 - Take multiple shots from different angles to see how the color appears under various lighting conditions. G3

6. Thickness
- Fold multiple layers together and capture the
 - Shoot from an edge perspective to highlight
 - Place an object behind the fabric to demons

2. Material
- Capture close-up shots to highlight fabric weave or fiber structure. G1
 - Show different folds or drapes to emphasize material behavior. G7
 - Show natural creases of the material G6
 - Use side lighting to create soft shadows that define the fabric's texture. G4
 - Use props along with the fabric such as natural dyes, material yarn etc. G8

3. Quality
- Take a macro shot of stitching, embroidery, or fabric weave to showcase craftsmanship. G1
 - Show the edges of the fabric G2
 - Capture the product in flow (e.g., a saree being draped or a curtain hanging naturally). G7
 - Include an artisan's hand touching the fabric to suggest quality perception. G8



Some aspects to consider



1. They have smartphones and use it sometimes.
2. They may or may not have clicked photographs of their products previously to post it on social media.
3. They may or may not have got any training regarding clicking pictures.
4. They have very basic understanding of folding fabric.

Preset 1

Full Saree Display

(Color, Pattern, Material)

- Grid Type: Rule of Thirds (3×3 grid)
- Product Placement: Saree should be spread out flat or draped over a surface.
- Purpose: Show the full saree to highlight color, pattern, and material.
- Guidelines:
 - Ensure the saree covers most of the frame.
 - Keep the top border aligned with the top third of the grid for a balanced composition.
 - If draped, the pleats should align with vertical grid lines.



Preset 2

Close-up of Texture & Weave

(Texture, Thickness, Material, Transparency)

- Grid Type: Center Focus Grid (Guides artisans to focus on a small section)
- Product Placement: A well-lit section of the saree, preferably in natural light.
- Purpose: Capture texture, thickness, and weave quality.
- Guidelines:
 - Ensure the saree fills most of the frame.
 - Keep texture details in the center grid.
 - Use soft light to avoid harsh reflections.



Preset 3

Draped Look

(Flimsiness, Sheen, Flow, weight)

- Grid Type: Leading Lines Grid (Diagonal guidelines to guide fabric flow)
- Product Placement: Drape the saree over a hanger, bamboo, or mannequin.
- Purpose: Showcase how the saree flows, its flimsiness, and weight.
- Guidelines:
 - Let the saree fall naturally.
 - Position folds or drapes along the diagonal grid lines.
 - Use a side light source to capture sheen.

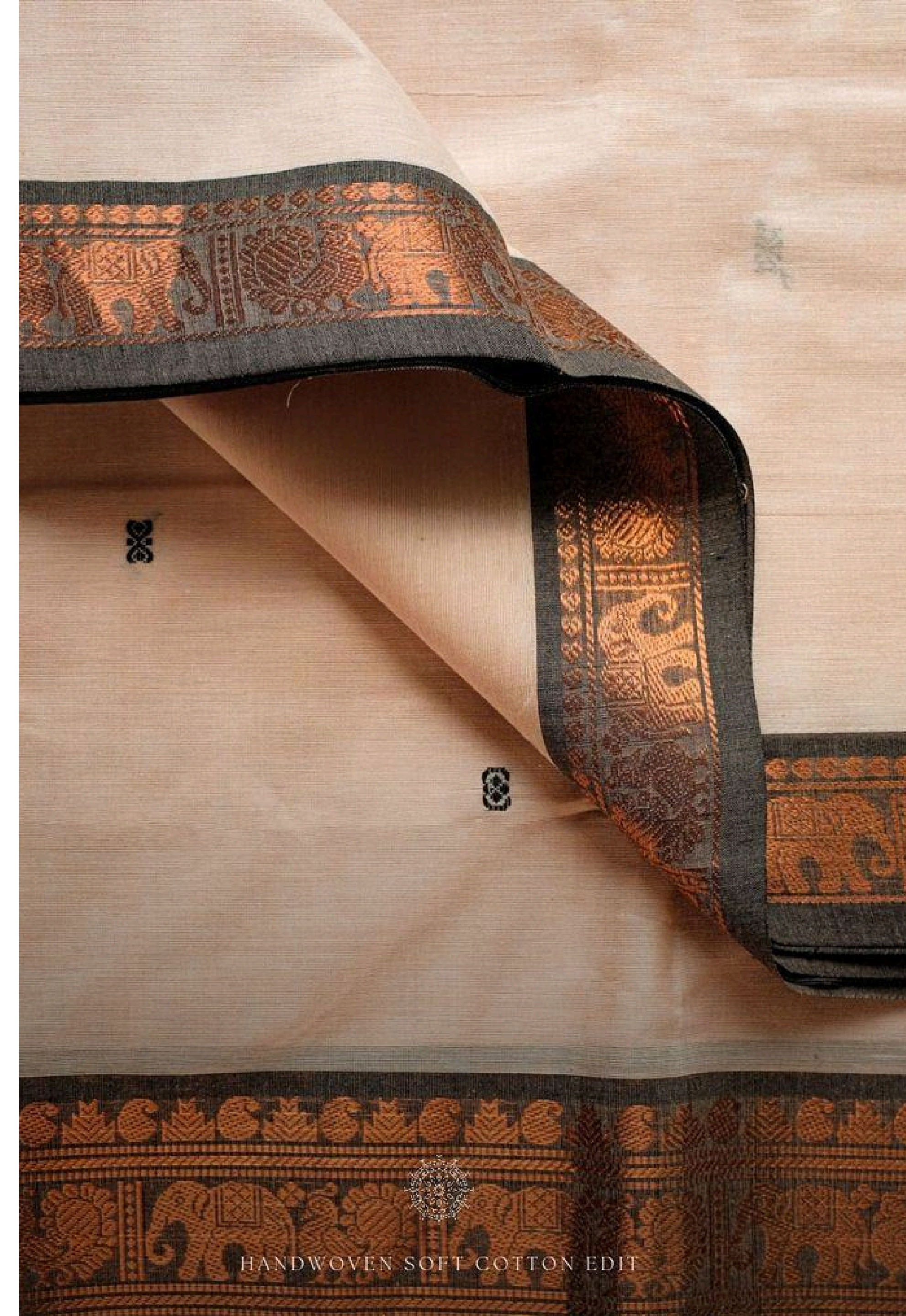


Preset 4

Embroidery & Border Details

(Embroidery, Quality)

- Grid Type: Detail Frame Grid (Small rectangle for embroidery focus) and leading lines
- Product Placement: Close-up of the saree border or an embroidered section.
- Purpose: Highlight embroidery details and fabric quality.
- Guidelines:
 - Keep embroidery inside the highlighted frame.
 - Use side lighting and ensure the details are sharp and well-lit.
 - Use a contrast background for better visibility.



HANDWOVEN SOFT COTTON EDIT

Preset 5

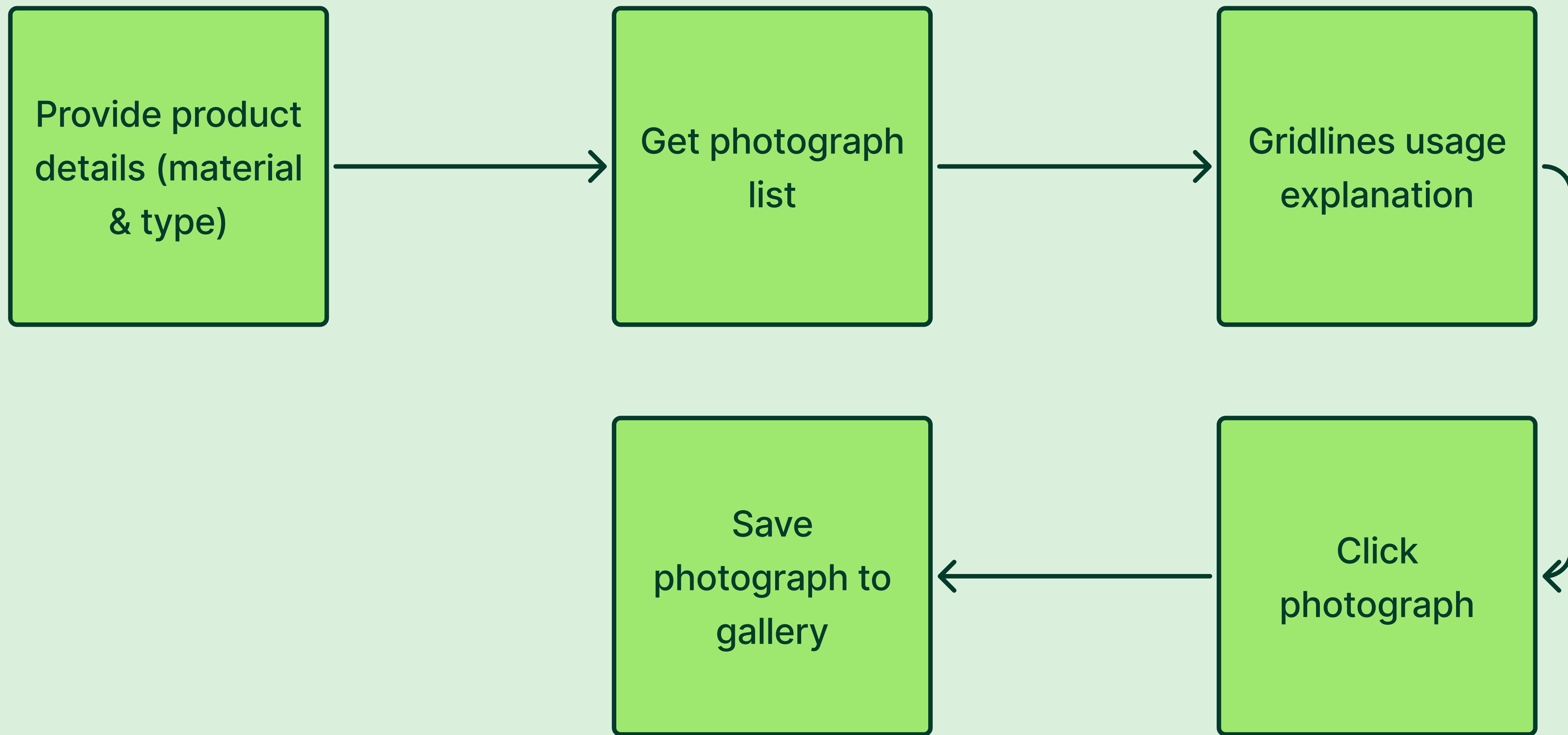
Folded Stack

(Thickness & Material)

- Grid Type: Horizontal and diagonal Lines Grid (For aligning folds)
- Product Placement: Stack the saree neatly with visible folds.
- Purpose: Show thickness and material weight.
- Guidelines:
 - Keep folds parallel to horizontal grid lines.
 - Use side lighting for depth.
 - Make sure the edge of the saree is visible for thickness reference.



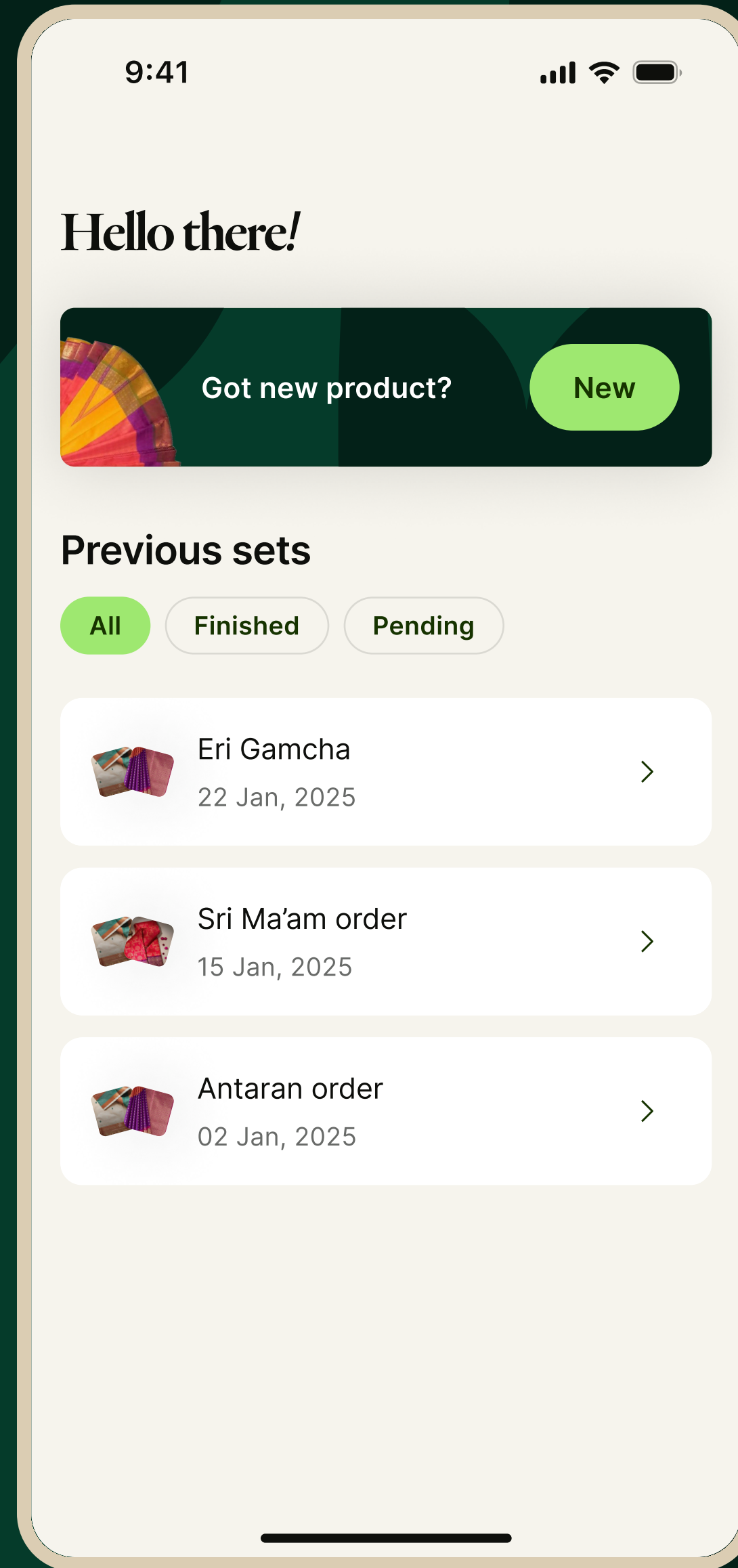
Flow of the process



Know what photos to take

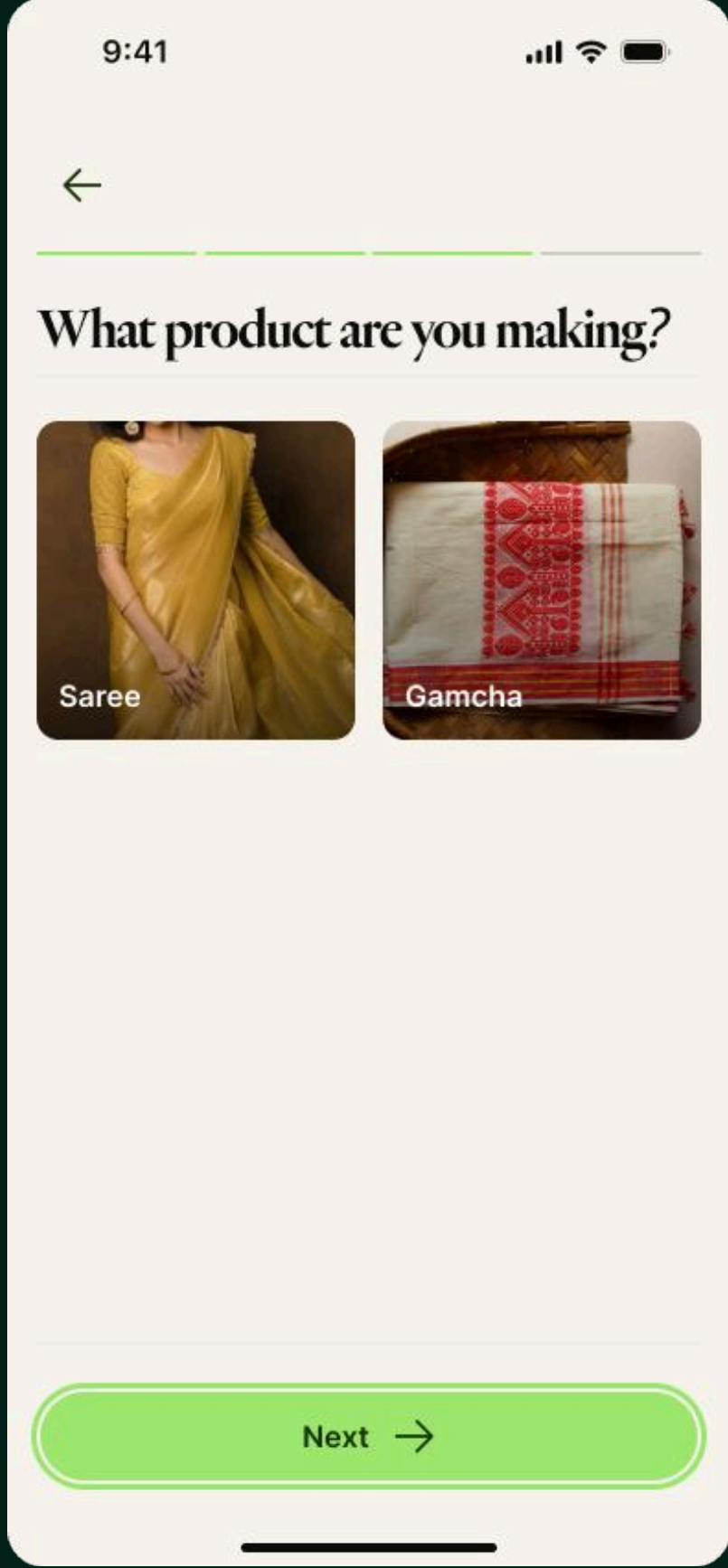
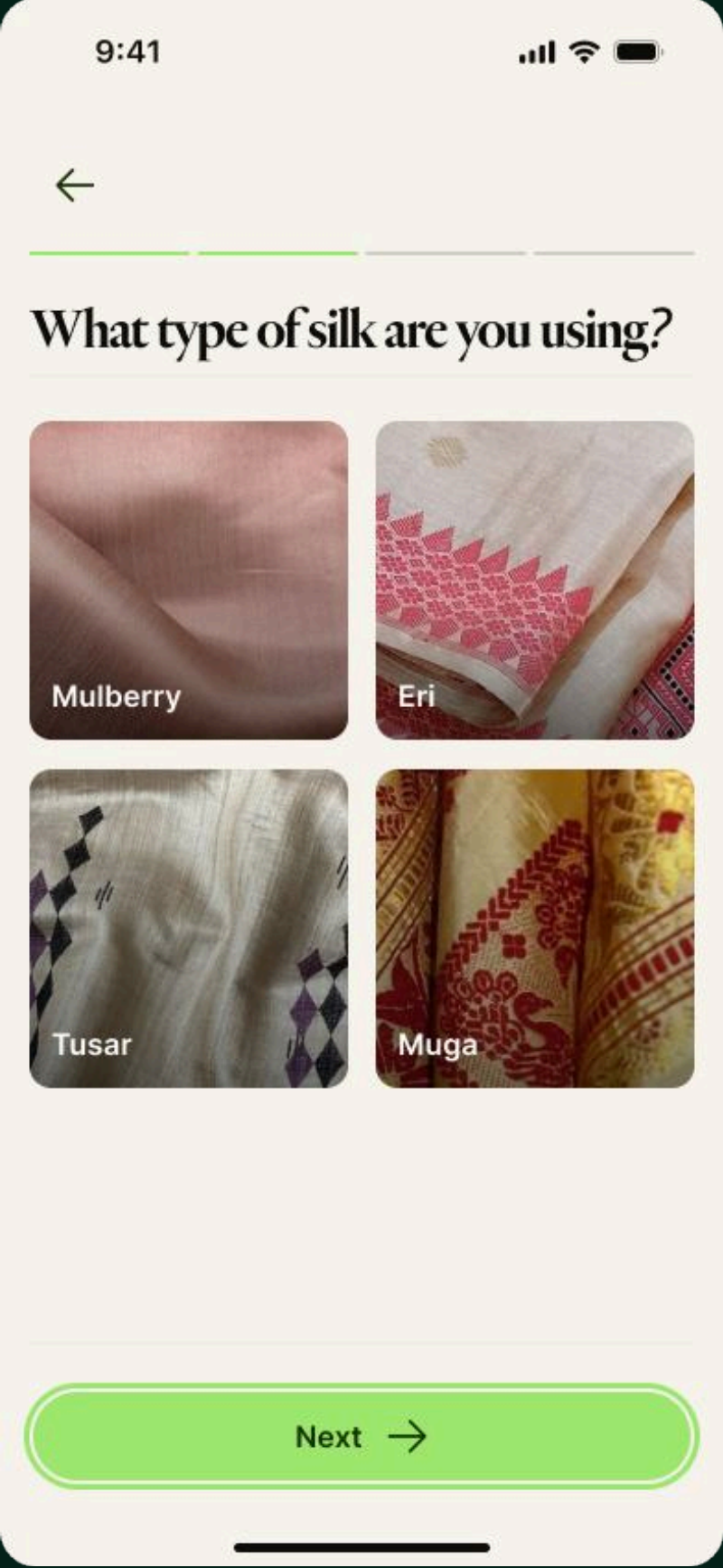
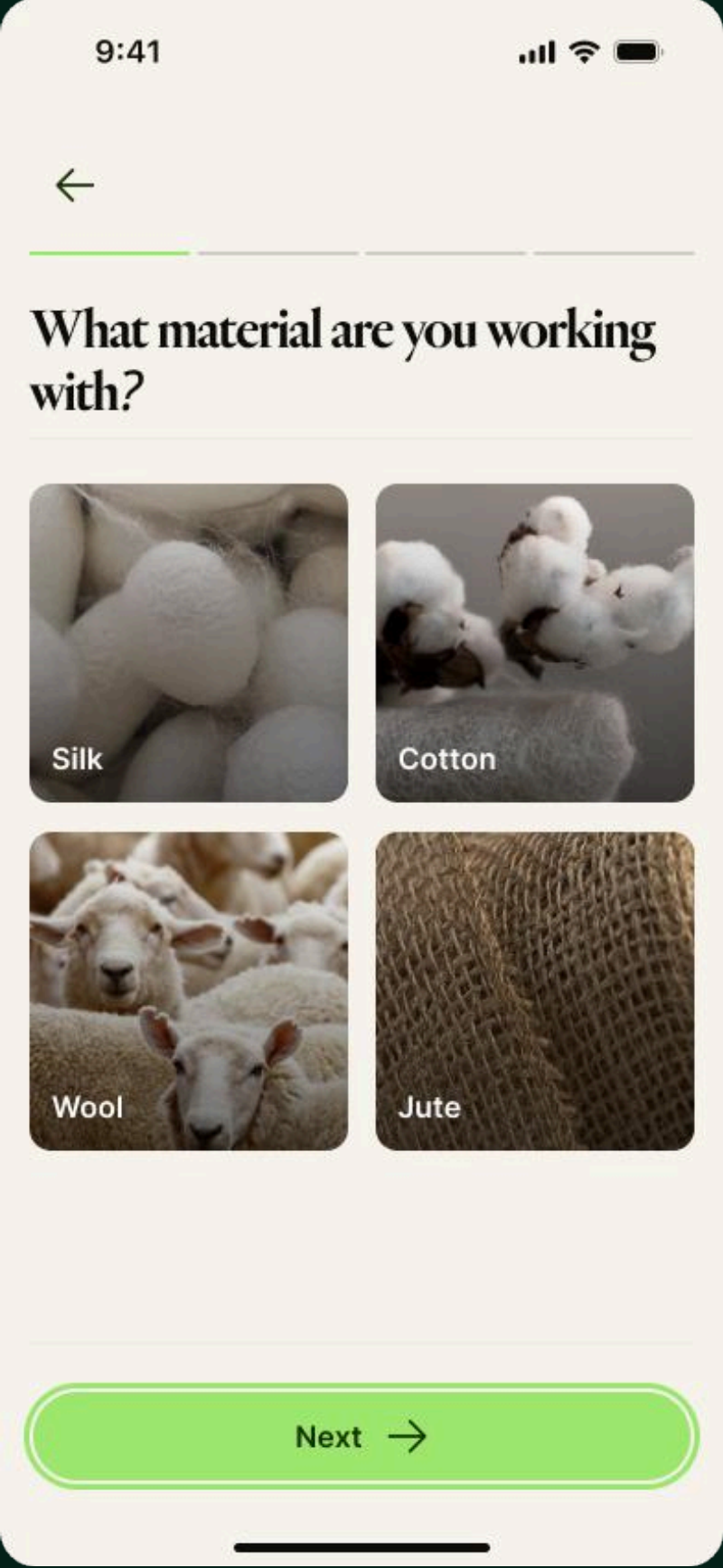
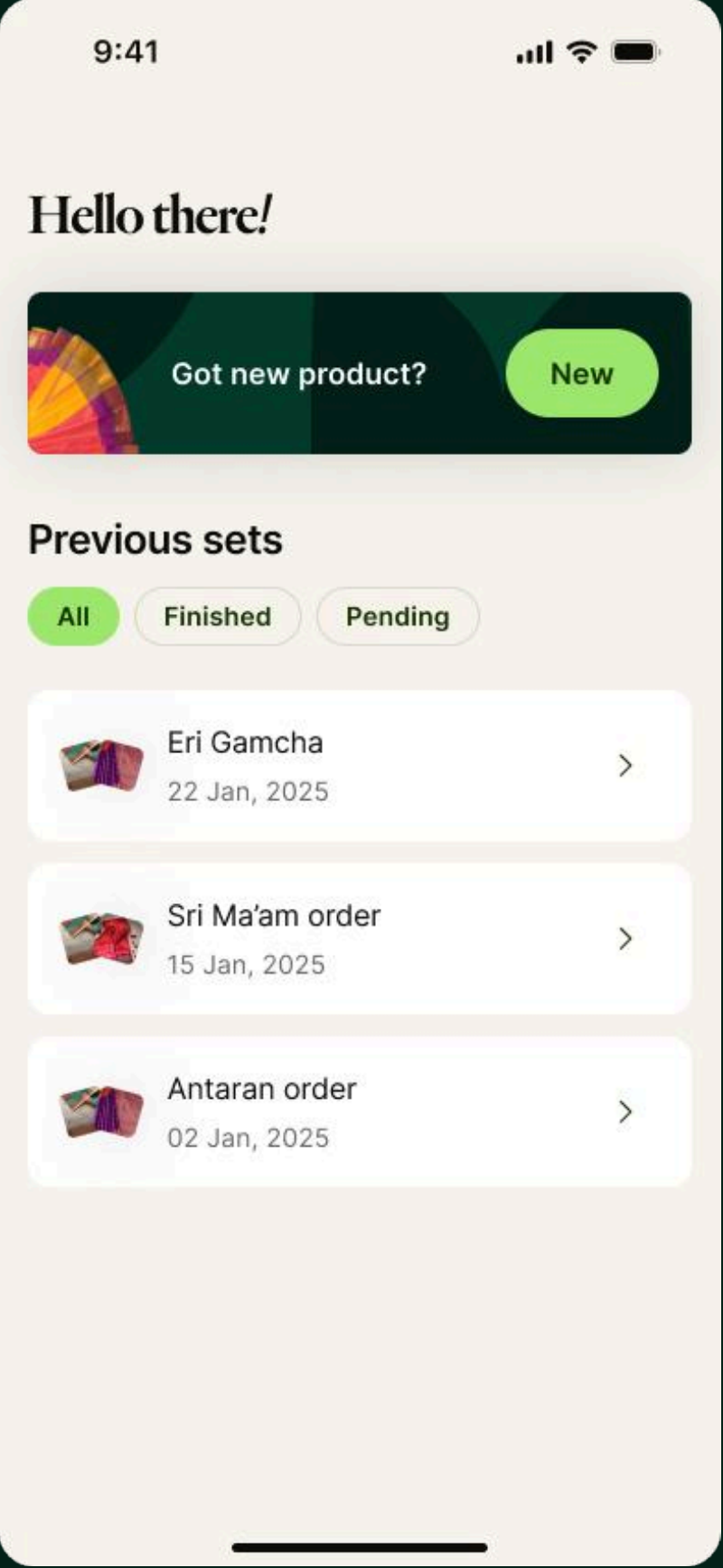


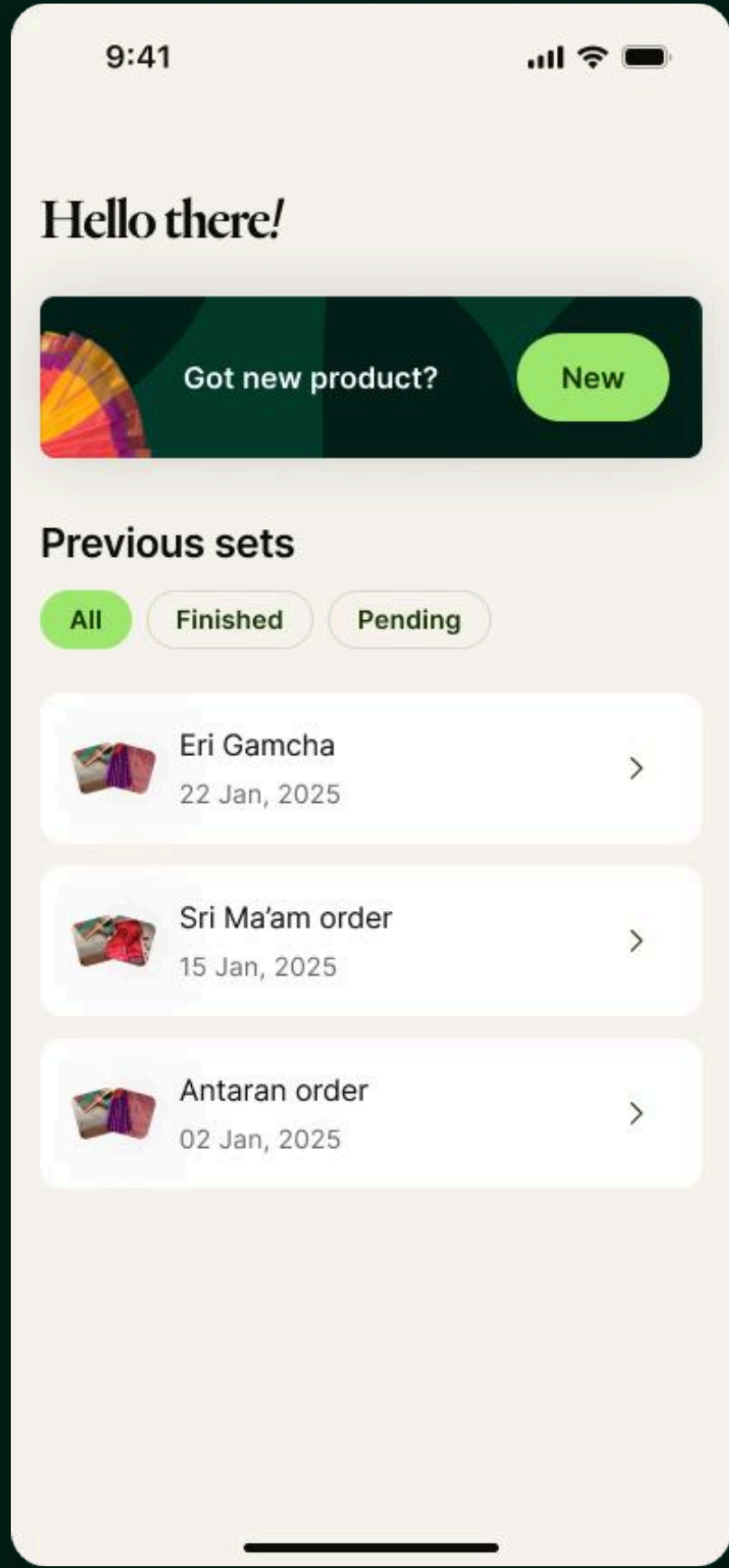
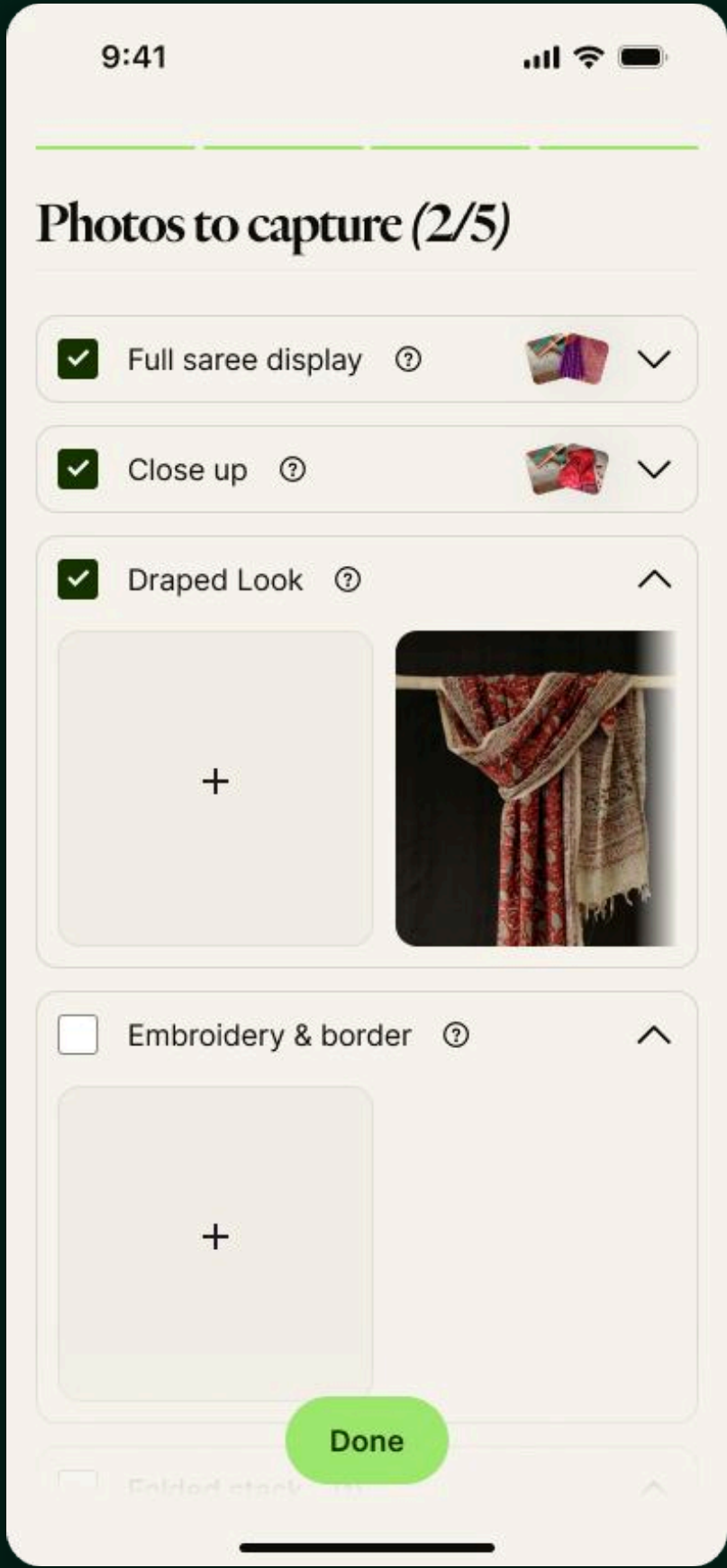
Get the best camera settings
and grid overlays

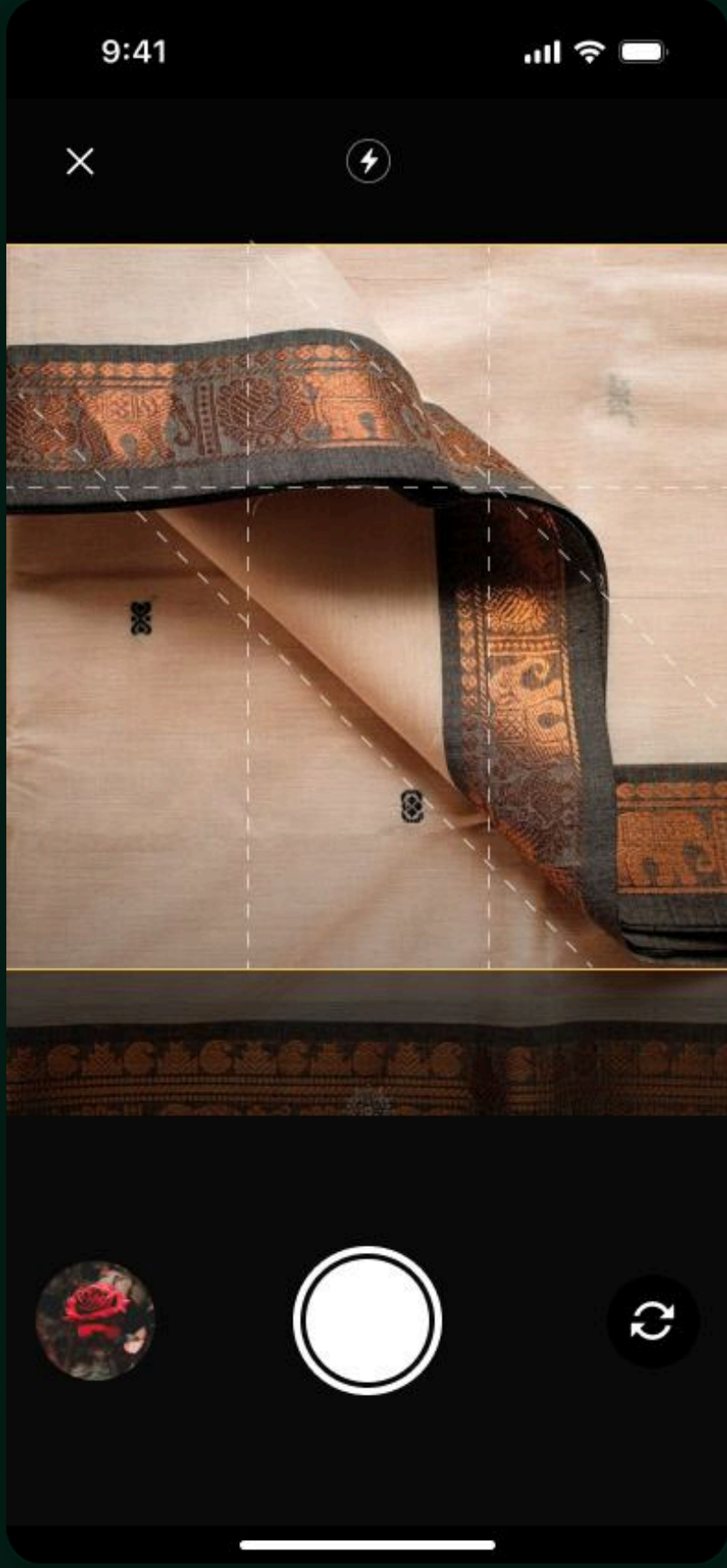
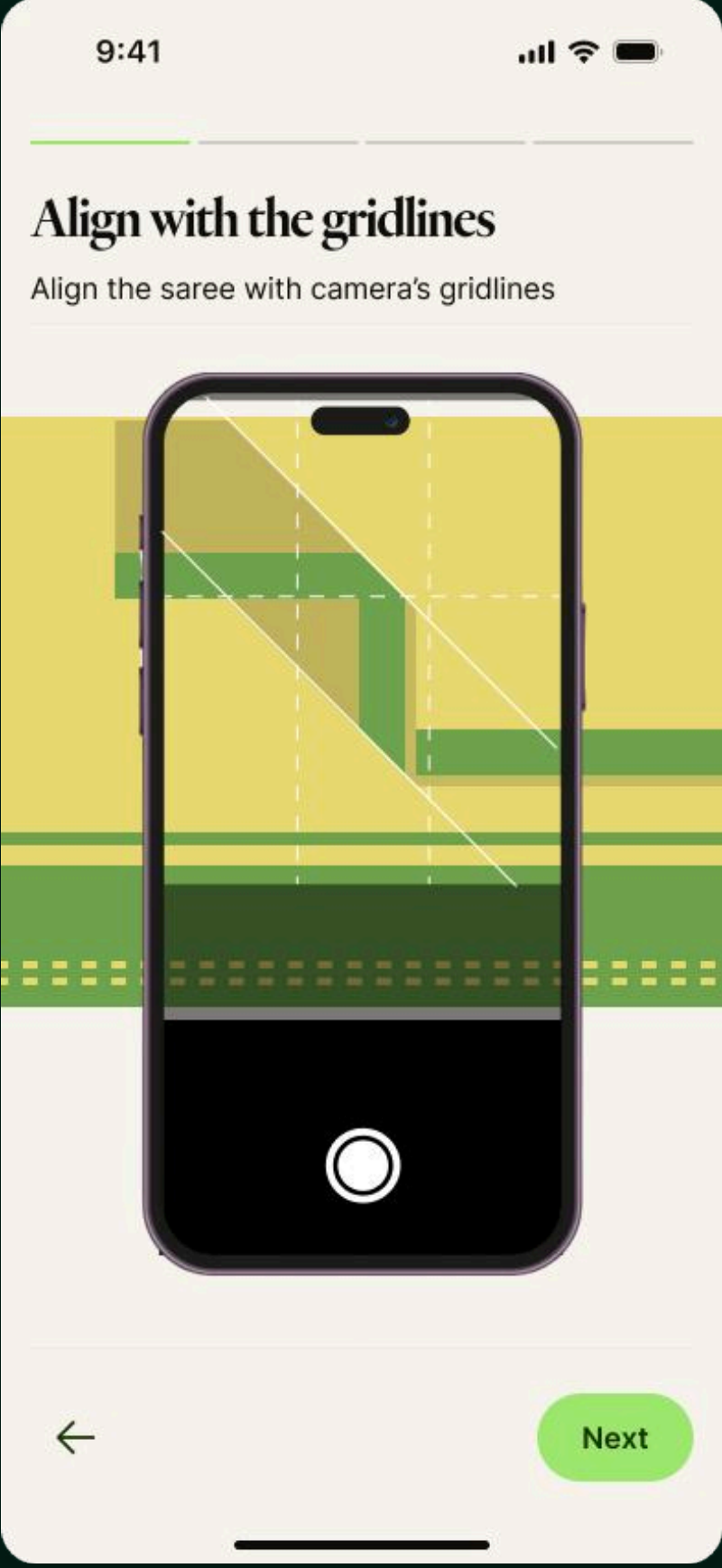
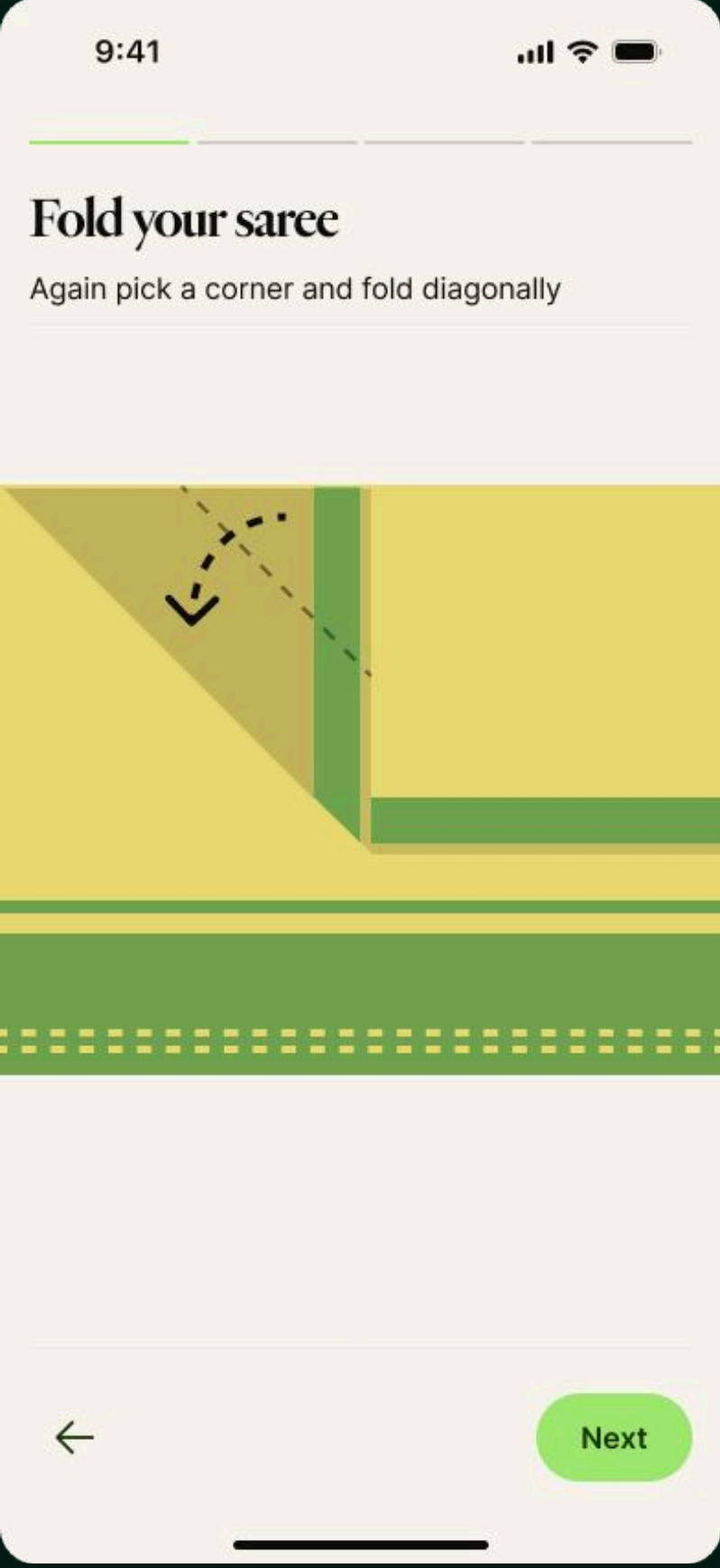
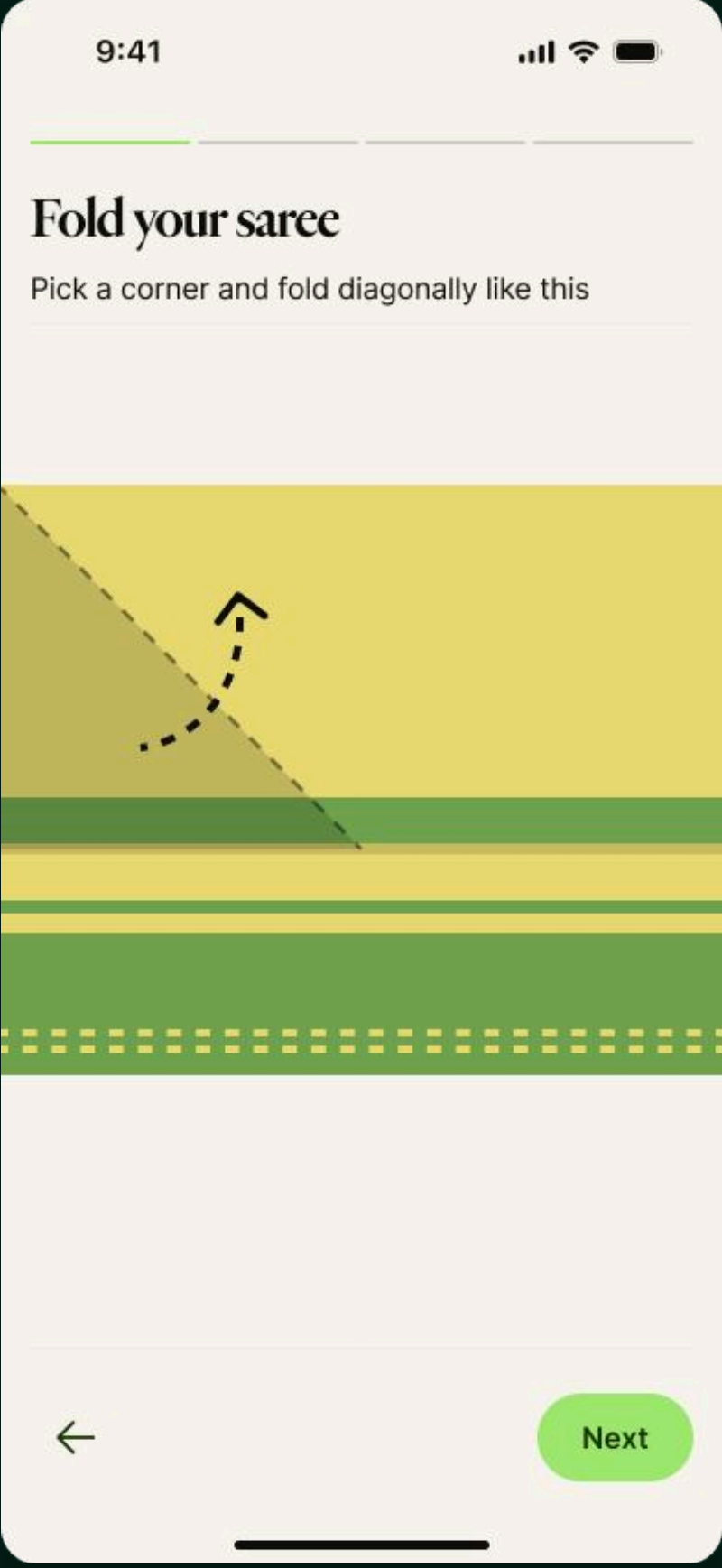
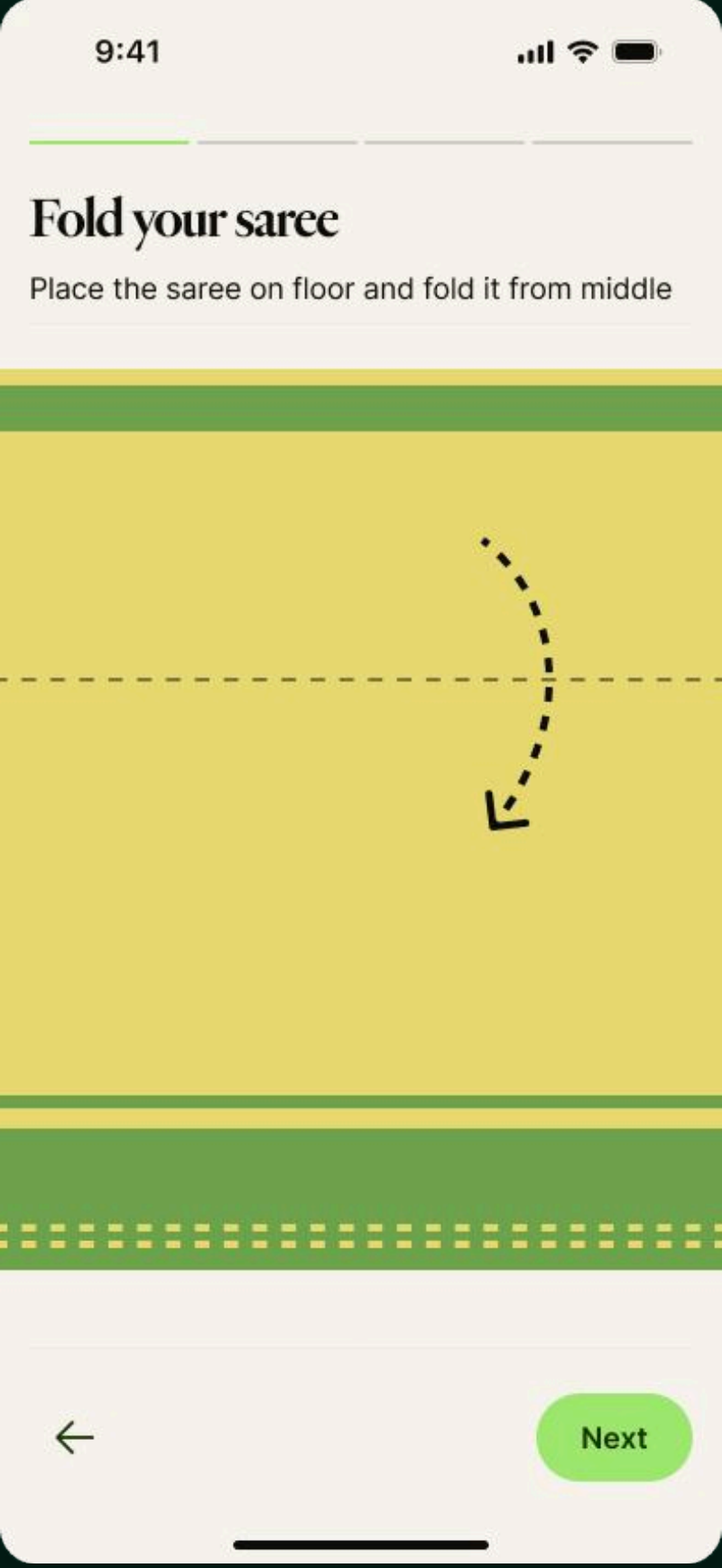


No product photography experience?











User Testing

To evaluate the usability and effectiveness of the prototype, user testing sessions were conducted with eight female handloom artisans from the Kamrup cluster in Assam.





- All participants were females and **active handloom artisans**.
- **3 had never used a smartphone** before (5 out of 8 owned smartphones)
- Only **1 participant had prior experience in photographing** her products for digital use.



Findings of user testing

- Artisans often required additional **verbal guidance** to correctly set up the product.
- Most participants **did not read** on-screen instructions and relied mainly on visual diagrams.
- Artisans showed **limited understanding of optimal lighting** conditions and where to place the product in relation to natural light.
- Once one artisan was guided, the others were able to learn quickly by **observing** and continued without needing further instruction.

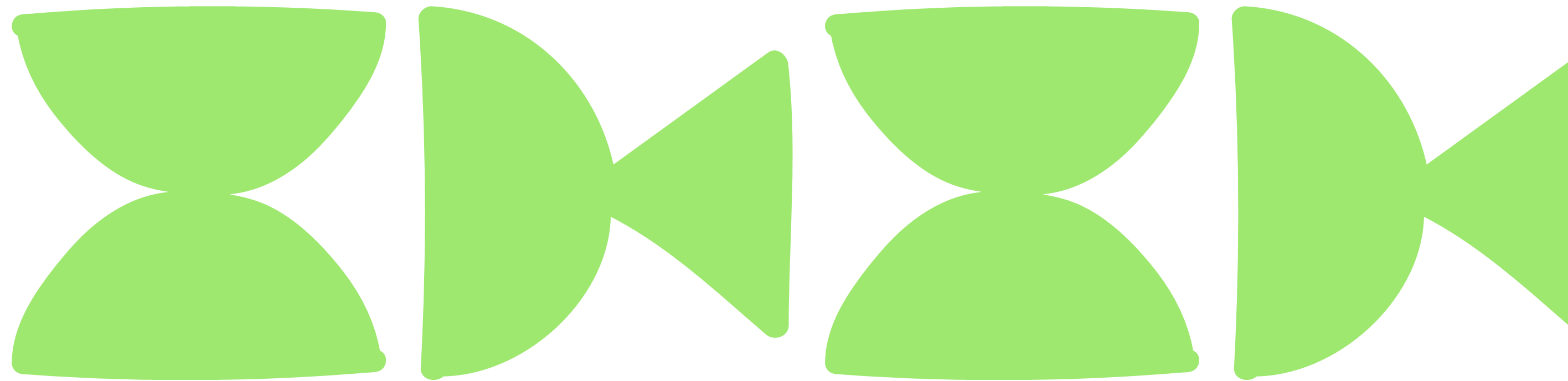
Findings of user testing

- A key challenge was the **inability to identify good lighting**. Despite daylight availability, artisans often attempted to take photos indoors in poor lighting.
- Basic steps, such as **pressing the fabric edges** to prevent curling, were not followed intuitively.
- In the second setup with a bamboo frame, artisans **struggled to align** the bamboo with the on-screen guideline, not realizing the line was for alignment assistance.



Findings of user testing

- Low opacity of the guide lines made them **difficult to see**, especially under bright outdoor sunlight.
- In contrast, artisans were able to align the product successfully using the grid in the first setup, which did not require **external objects**.



Text-based instruction is ineffective

Key details were not obvious

Diagrams didn't communicate

Struggled to identify good lighting

Low opacity of guides

Avoid external props

UI with visual alignment cues

Learning is social



Improvements in the pictures



Previously clicked images



Clicked using provided templates

Improvements in the pictures

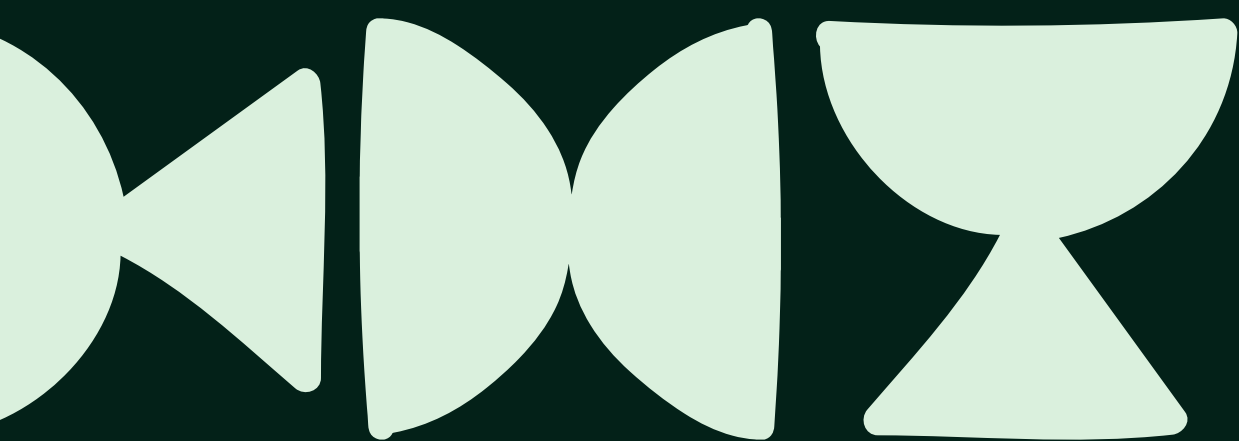


Previously clicked
images



Clicked using
provided templates

- Improved alignment and layout
- Clearer visibility of fabric properties (texture, weight, etc.)
- Sharper, unhazy images
- More engaging and well-structured compositions
- Better presentation of borders, motifs, and details



**How did we respond to
the problems?**

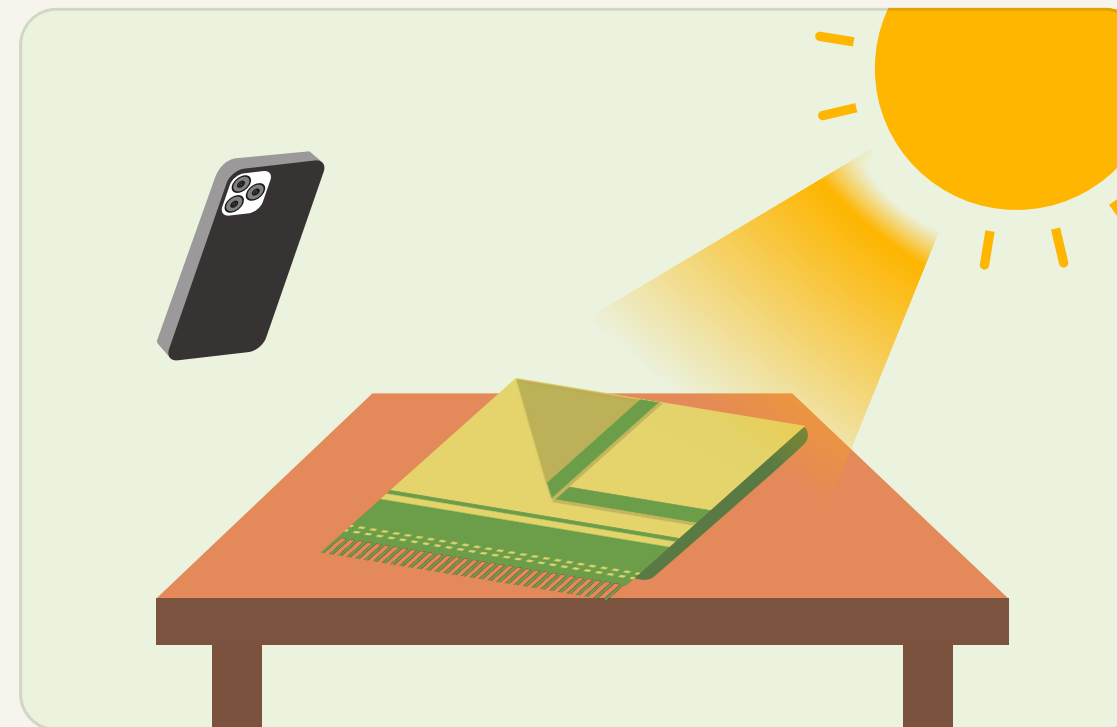
Help with the light

Gaps

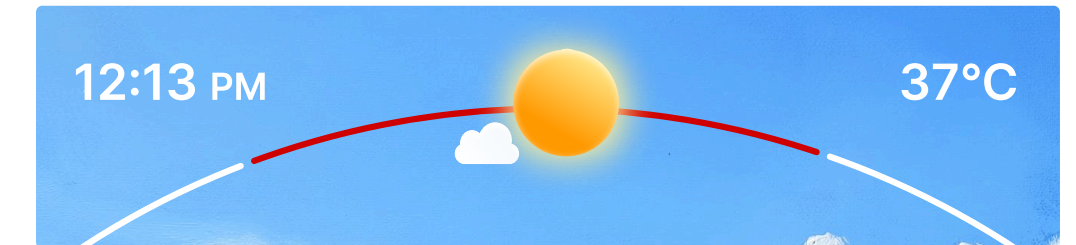
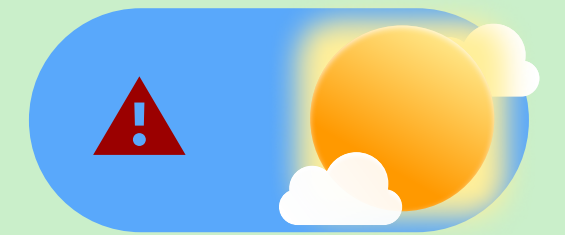
- Artisans struggled to identify good lighting conditions.
- No real-time feedback or cues were given on lighting quality.
- UI not tested for outdoor visibility — sunlight drastically reduces visibility of soft overlays.

Suggestions

- Add light quality detection with real-time guidance.
- Add visual samples of good vs. bad lighting during onboarding.
- Use icons or sun/cloud graphics to show recommended light conditions.



Use natural light coming from one direction to avoid unwanted shadows on your setup



⚠ Overhead sun

Maybe wait till **3:30 PM**

Try taking the photo later when the sunlight is softer. Right now, the overhead sun may cause harsh shadows on your setup.

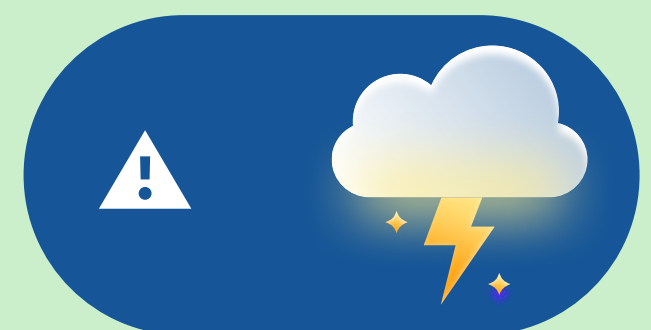
⚠ Do not click photos in:



**Hazy or
Cloudy Days**



**Midday
12 pm - 2 pm**



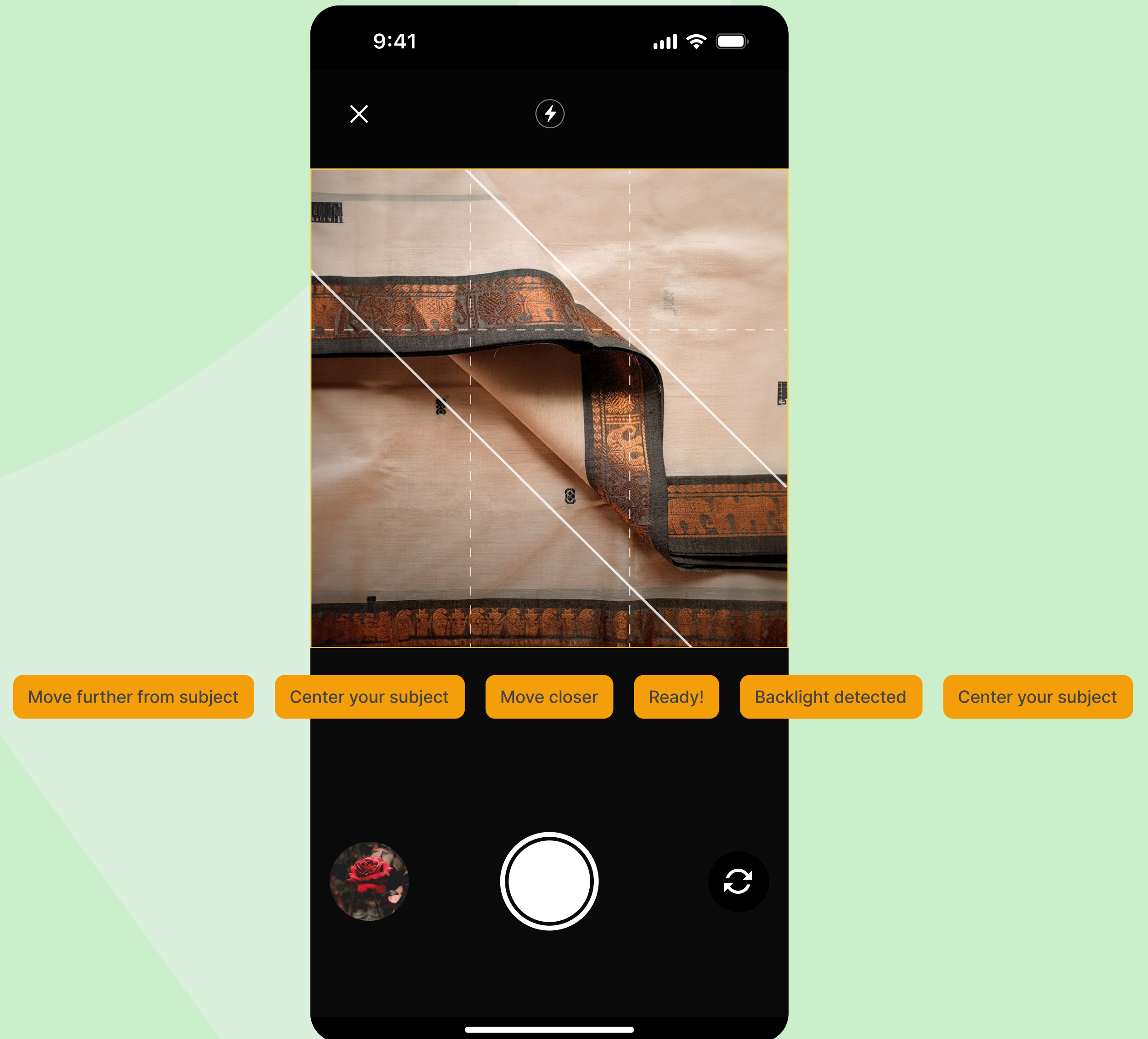
Help with alignment

Gaps

- No clear cue that they were supposed to align with the guide.
- UI not tested for outdoor visibility — sunlight drastically reduces visibility of soft overlays.

Suggestions

- Integration of live visual cues within the camera interface to assist artisans during the photo-capturing process.
- Redesign guides with high-contrast, thick lines for outdoor use.



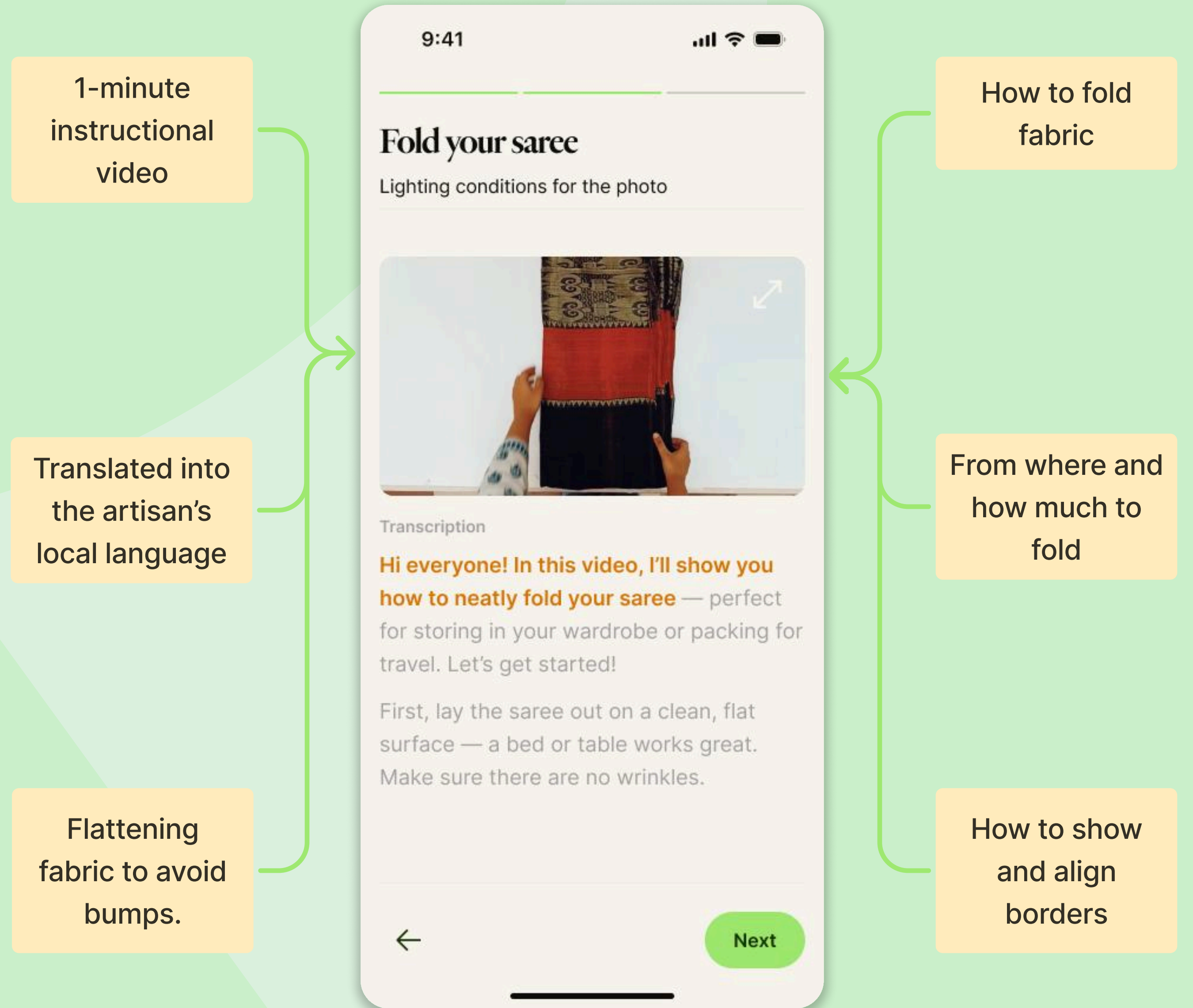
Help with the set-up

Gaps

- Reliance on text-based instructions is ineffective.
- Even photos/diagrams alone didn't communicate detailed actions clearly enough.
- Key details (e.g. border placement, edge flattening) were not obvious from visual cues.
- Learning is social and observational — instructions weren't self-explanatory or self-sufficient.

Suggestions

- Replace text-heavy screens with video instructions or animated sequences showing step-by-step action (especially for folding/orienting).
- Add voiceover in Assamese to supplement visuals, even short and direct.



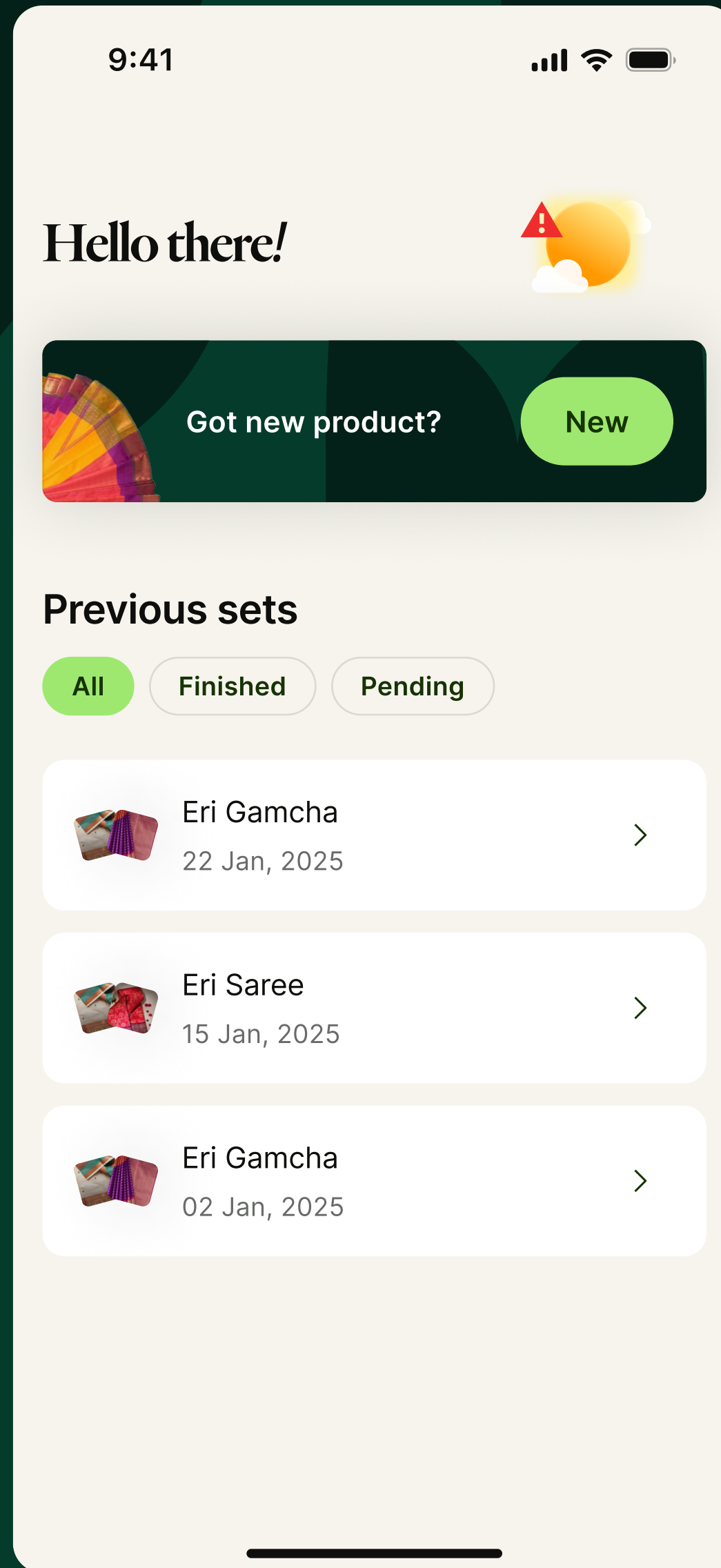
Nudges to improve your photos



Light warning add



Video instructions added



9:41

Hello there!

Got new product?

New

Previous sets

All

Finished

Pending

Eri Gamcha

22 Jan, 2025

Eri Saree

15 Jan, 2025

Eri Gamcha

02 Jan, 2025

9:41

What material are you working with?

Silk

Cotton

Wool

Jute

Next →

9:41

What type of silk are you using?

Mulberry

Eri

Tusar

Muga

Next →

9:41

What product are you making?

Saree

Gamcha

Next →

9:41

Eri Saree

Done

Draped Look

→

Texture & Weave

→

Embroidery & Border

→

Full Saree

April 28

3 →

Saree Stack

April 28

3 →

9:41

Place your saree

Lighting conditions for the photo

Use natural light coming from one direction to avoid unwanted shadows on your setup

⚠ Do not click photos in:

Hazy or Cloudy Days

Midday 12 pm - 2 pm

←

Next

9:41

Place your saree

Lighting conditions for the photo

Use natural light coming from one direction to avoid unwanted shadows on your setup

⚠ Do not click photos in:

12:13 PM

37°C

⚠ Overhead sun

Maybe wait till 3:30 PM

Try taking the photo later when the sunlight is softer. Right now, the overhead sun may cause harsh shadows on your setup.

9:41

Fold your saree

Lighting conditions for the photo



Transcription

Hi everyone! In this video, I'll show you **how to neatly fold your saree** — perfect for storing in your wardrobe or packing for travel. Let's get started!

First, lay the saree out on a clean, flat surface — a bed or table works great. Make sure there are no wrinkles.

←

Next

9:41



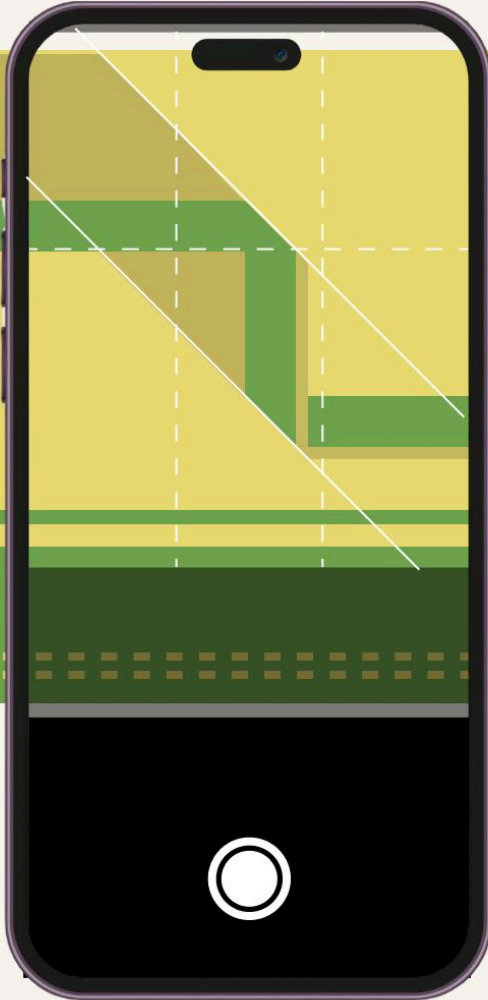
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Next

9:41

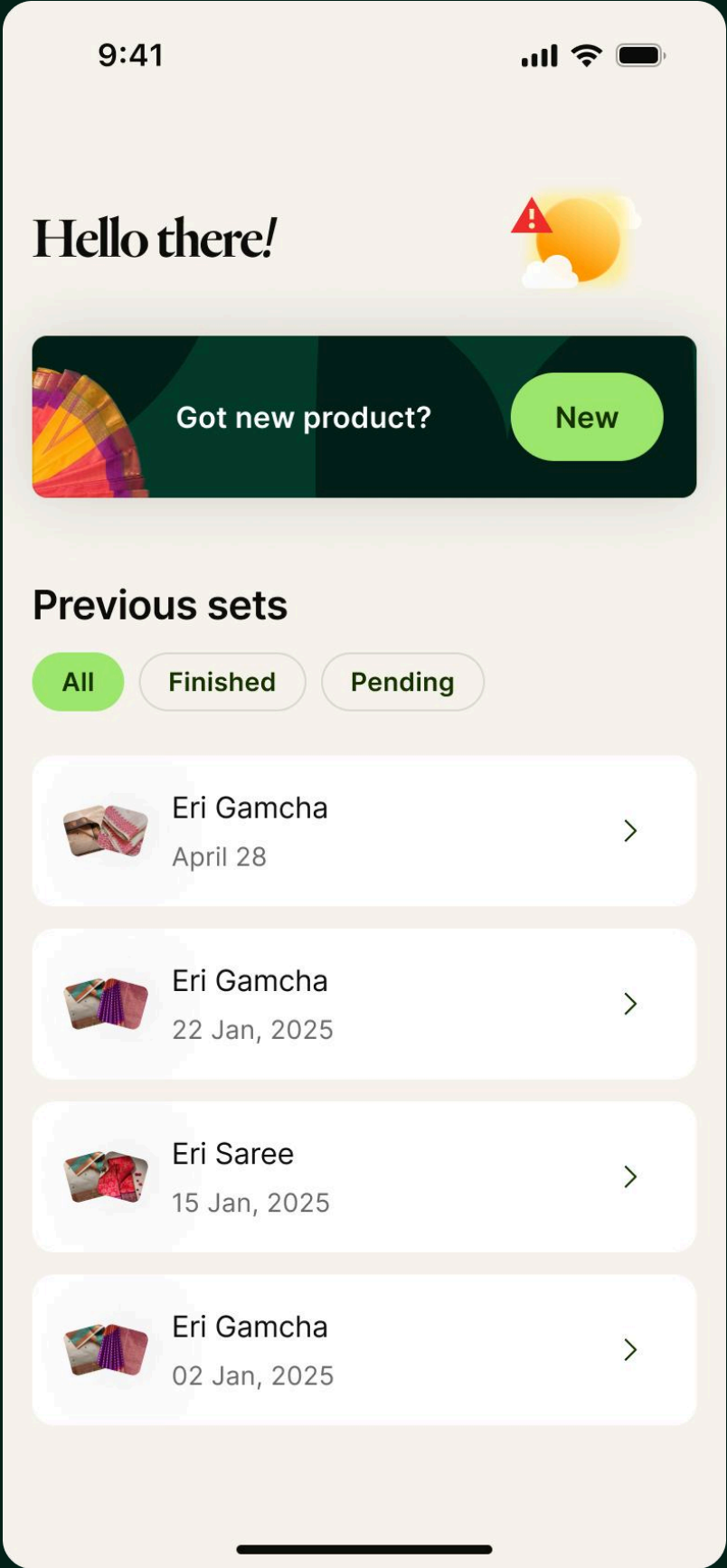
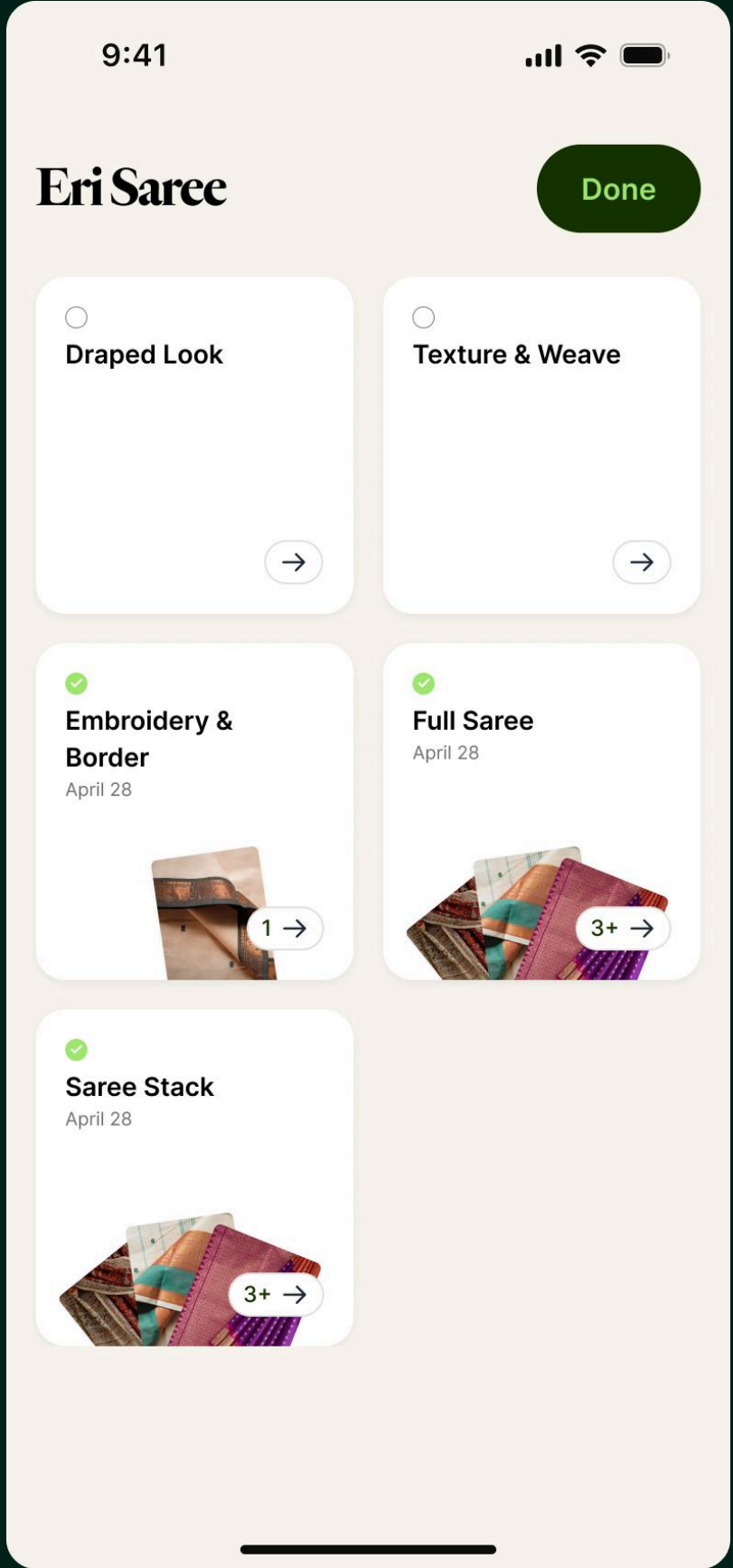
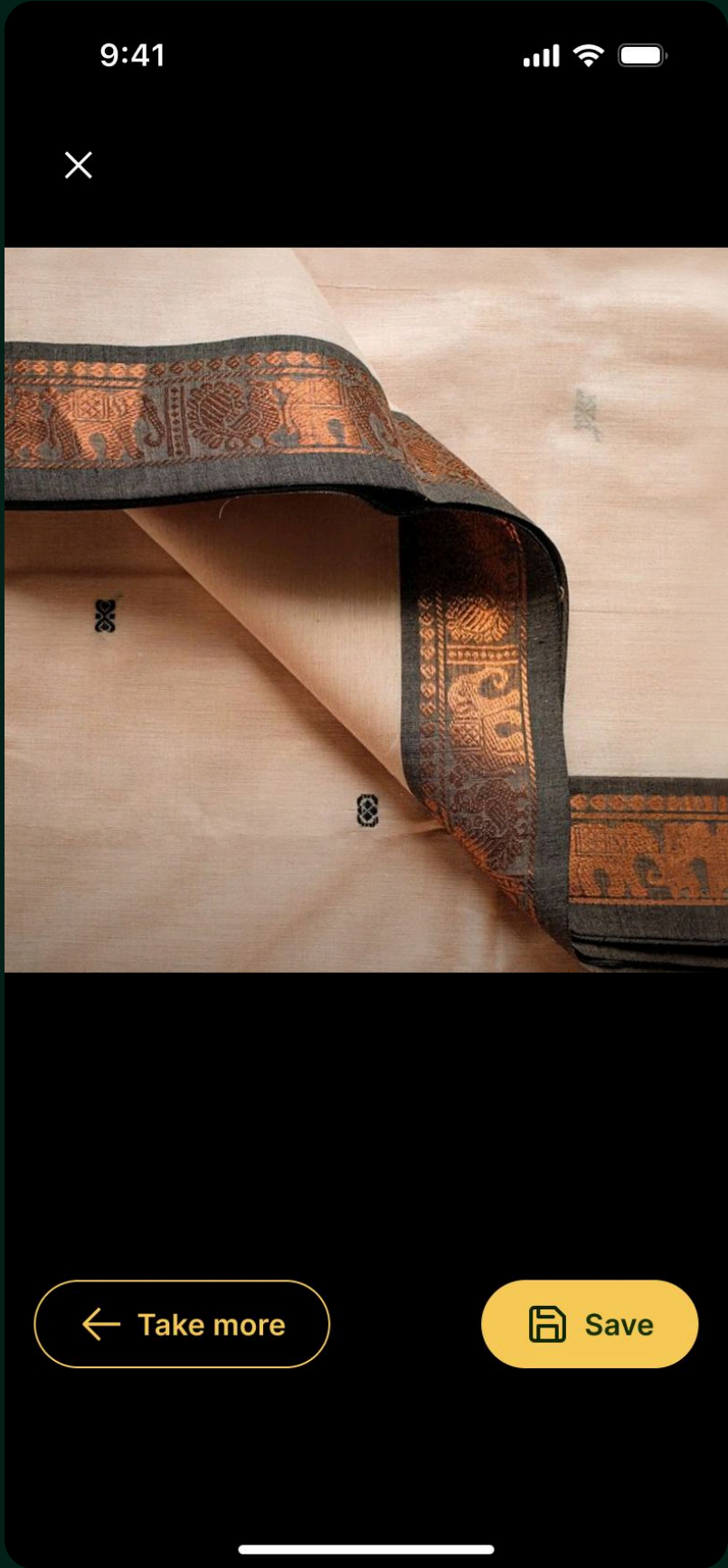
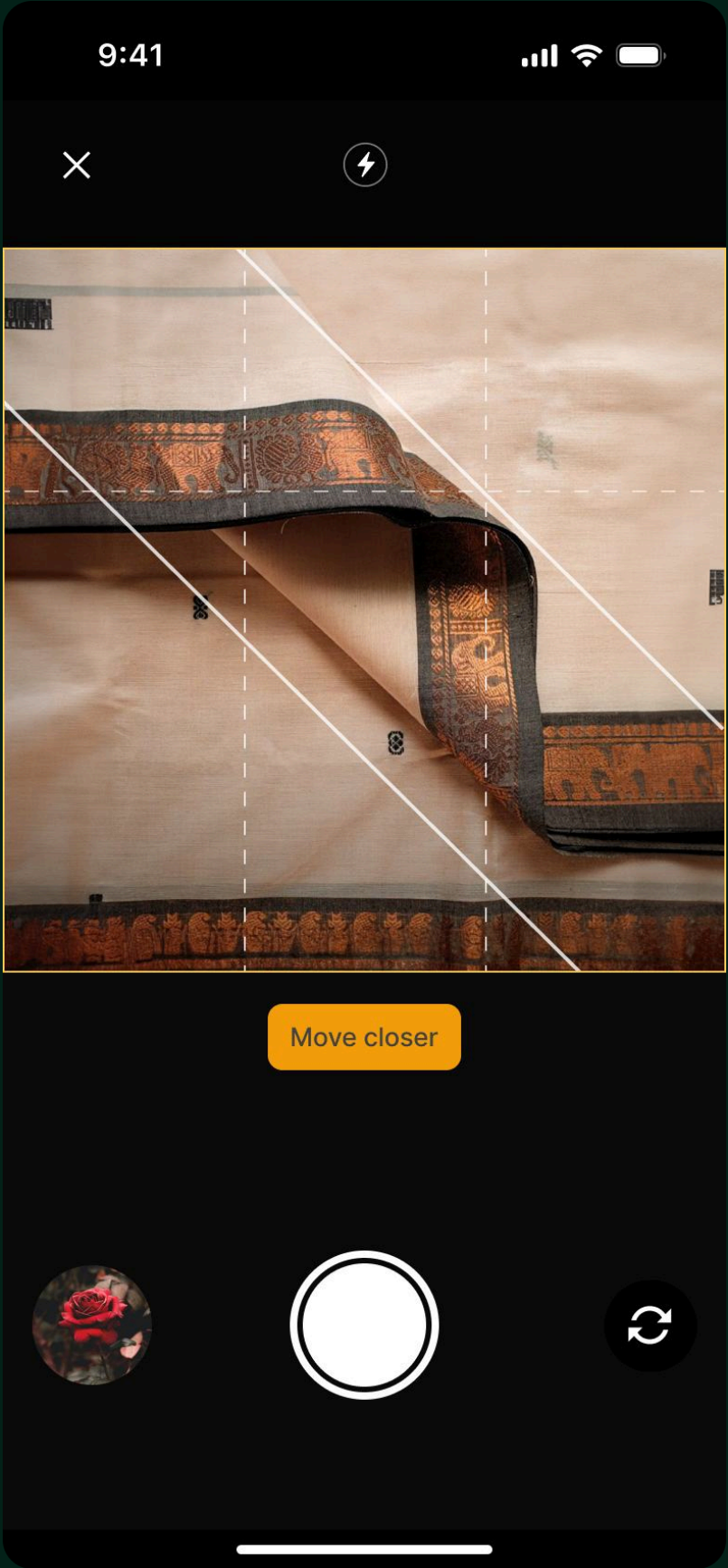
Align with the gridlines

Align the saree with camera's gridlines



←

Next



Future steps

- Expand gridline support to cover a wider range of products, offering tailored guides for each.
- Explore AI integration to assist with photo alignment and potentially automate parts of the product photography process.
- Enable social media support by providing tools that help artisans post their photographs online, including assistance with writing captions.



Thank you